Chapter 64 — Chat / Messaging Architecture

> **Part VIII — Real-Time & Connectivity** · Complexity: **Complex** (≥40 interview questions)
>
> **Prerequisites:** Ch 63 (WebSocket), Ch 49 (FCM), Ch 31 (outbox), Ch 32 (delta sync), Ch 15 (idempotency), Ch 3 (SSOT), Ch 13 (paging), Ch 44 (lifecycle). Pairs with Ch 65 (presence/typing), Ch 66 (SSE/long-poll), Ch 72 (optimistic updates).
>
> **Reference surface in StreamCart:** buyer ↔ seller chat, support chat, and group conversations — messages that send reliably offline, arrive in real time, show correct delivery/read status, survive reconnects and process death, and stay consistent across devices.

64.1 Problem Definition and Real-World Context

Chat is the canonical "hard" mobile feature because it combines **every** distributed- systems problem into one UI: reliable sending (offline, retries), real-time receiving (WebSocket, Ch 63), background delivery (FCM, Ch 49), **ordering**, **deduplication**, **delivery/read receipts**, **optimistic UI** (Ch 72), **pagination of history** (Ch 13), **multi-device consistency** (Ch 32), and **process-death survival** (Ch 3/8). A naive chat ("POST a message, append to a list") fails the moment the network blips, the app backgrounds, two devices are used, or messages race.

Concretely, teams hit:

- **Unreliable sending.** A message sent while offline/flaky is lost, or double-sent on retry. Must use an **outbox** (Ch 31) with **idempotency keys** (Ch 15) and optimistic insert (Ch 72).
- **Ordering & dedup.** Messages arrive out of order (retries, multi-path WebSocket+FCM), or duplicated. Need a **server-assigned sequence/clock** and **dedup by client-id + server-seq** (Ch 15/63).
- **Real-time + background split.** Live delivery over WebSocket (Ch 63) while foreground; **FCM** (Ch 49) to notify/sync when backgrounded — one coherent pipeline, not two inconsistent ones.
- **Delivery & read receipts.** Sent → delivered → read status per message, synced both ways, is its own state machine and consistency problem.
- **History & sync.** Paginate history (Ch 13), **catch up** missed messages on reconnect via a cursor (Ch 32), and reconcile across devices — the socket is a fast path, the **SSOT + server are truth** (Ch 3/63).
- **Multi-device & groups.** The same conversation on phone + tablet must converge; group chats fan out to many participants (server concern) with per-user state.
- **Process death / offline-first.** Draft messages, unsent outbox, and history must survive process death and work offline (Ch 3/8/29).

The architecture: model chat as an **offline-first, SSOT-backed** feature (Room, Ch 3) — **optimistically insert** a message with a **client-generated id** into the local store and an **outbox** (Ch 31/72), **send with idempotency** (Ch 15) over the current transport, and **confirm** with the server's assigned **sequence**; **receive** live via **WebSocket** (Ch 63) while foreground and via **FCM** (Ch 49) when backgrounded, both funneling into the **same idempotent SSOT merge** (dedup by client-id/server-seq, ordered by server sequence); **catch up** missed messages on reconnect/open via a **cursor** (Ch 32); maintain **delivery/read receipts** as synced per-message state; **paginate** history (Ch 13); and

keep it **consistent across devices** with the server as truth. This chapter is the **end-to-end architecture of a reliable, real-time, offline-first chat**.

Three practical use cases

1. **Buyer↔seller chat (StreamCart).** Send works offline (outbox, optimistic), delivers live via WebSocket, notifies via FCM when backgrounded, shows sent/delivered/read, and survives reconnect with catch-up.
2. **Support chat with history.** Paginated history (Ch 13), catch-up on reopen, read receipts, consistent across the user's devices.
3. **Group conversation.** Fan-out delivery (server), per-user read state, ordering by server sequence, dedup across WebSocket+FCM paths.

Why this is architectural

Chat **composes** the whole book: networking (Ch 1), WebSocket (Ch 63), FCM (Ch 49), outbox (Ch 31), idempotency (Ch 15), delta sync (Ch 32), SSOT (Ch 3), optimistic UI (Ch 72), paging (Ch 13), lifecycle (Ch 44). Its decisions — client-id + server-seq, unified real-time pipeline, receipts state machine, catch-up cursor, device convergence — are a masterclass in mobile distributed consistency.

64.2 Requirements Engineering

Functional requirements

ID	Requirement
F1	Send messages reliably: offline-capable, retried, idempotent, optimistic (Ch 31/15/72).
F2	Receive in real time (WebSocket) foreground + via FCM background — one pipeline (Ch 63/49).
F3	Order and dedup messages (client-id + server sequence) (Ch 15).
F4	Delivery/read receipts per message, synced both ways.
F5	Paginate history; catch up missed messages on reconnect/open (Ch 13/32).
F6	Consistent across devices; survive process death; offline-first (Ch 3/8/29).

Non-functional requirements

Attribute	Policy
Reliability	No lost/duplicated messages; send survives offline/death.
Latency	Real-time delivery while connected; prompt FCM when bg.
Consistency	Server-ordered; SSOT truth; devices converge (Ch 32).
Offline	Compose/read/queue offline; sync on reconnect (Ch 29).
Security	Authed transport, per-conversation authz, (optional) E2E (Ch 19/23).

Scope

- **In scope:** message model (client-id + server-seq), send path (outbox + idempotency + optimistic, Ch 31/15/72), unified receive (WebSocket foreground + FCM background → idempotent SSOT merge, Ch 63/49/3), ordering/dedup, delivery/read receipts, history paging + catch-up cursor (Ch 13/32), multi-device convergence, offline-first + process death (Ch 29/8), conversation list, (overview) groups + E2E.
- **Out of scope:** WebSocket internals (Ch 63), FCM internals (Ch 49), presence/typing (Ch 65), SSE/long-poll (Ch 66), outbox/sync/idempotency mechanics (Ch 31/32/15), optimistic-UI detail (Ch 72), E2E crypto depth, server fan-out implementation.

Assumptions & constraints

- WebSocket (Ch 63) + FCM (Ch 49), Room SSOT (Ch 3), outbox (Ch 31), WorkManager (Ch 30), Paging 3 (Ch 13). `minSdk 24`. Server assigns a **monotonic per-conversation sequence** and is the **source of truth**; transports are best-effort; messages carry a **client-generated id** for idempotency.

64.3 System Design Fundamentals

- **SSOT-backed, offline-first (Ch 3/29).** The **Room database is the source of truth** the UI renders (UDF, Ch 6). Sending and receiving both **mutate the SSOT**; the network (WebSocket/FCM/REST) **feeds** the SSOT, never the UI directly. This makes chat work offline, survive process death (Ch 8), and stay consistent.
- **Dual id scheme: client-id + server-seq (the backbone).** Every message has:
  - a **client-generated id** (UUID) created at compose time — used as the **idempotency key** (Ch 15) so retries/duplicates collapse, and to match the optimistic message to the server's confirmation.
  - a **server-assigned sequence** (monotonic per conversation) — the **ordering** key and the **catch-up cursor** (Ch 32). The client orders by server-seq; before confirmation, an optimistic message sorts by its local timestamp at the tail. Dedup = "seen this client-id or server-seq before? ignore." Ordering = "sort by server-seq." This pair solves the two hardest chat problems.
- **Send path (reliable, optimistic, Ch 31/15/72):**
  1. **Optimistically insert** the message into the SSOT with its client-id and a `status = Sending` → UI shows it instantly (Ch 72).
  2. **Enqueue in the outbox** (Ch 31) so it survives process death and offline.
  3. **Send** over the current transport (WebSocket if connected, else REST) with the **client-id as idempotency key** (Ch 15) → server dedups retries.
  4. **Confirm:** server returns the **assigned sequence + timestamp** → update the SSOT message `status = Sent`, set server-seq (re-sort). The ack flows back via WebSocket or the REST response. Offline/flaky: the outbox retries with backoff (Ch 2); idempotency makes retries safe.
- **Unified receive pipeline (WebSocket + FCM → one SSOT merge, Ch 63/49):**
  - **Foreground:** messages stream over **WebSocket** (Ch 63) → **idempotent upsert** into the SSOT (dedup by client-id/server-seq).
  - **Background:** a **high-priority FCM** (Ch 49) wakes the app → fetch new messages via REST catch-up (Ch 32) → same idempotent SSOT merge → notification (Ch 50).
  - **Crucially both paths converge on the same SSOT merge**, so a message delivered twice (WebSocket + FCM, or WebSocket + catch-up) is **deduped**, and the UI is consistent regardless of path.

- **Catch-up on reconnect/open (Ch 32).** Because transports drop, on reconnect/foreground the client sends its **last server-seq per conversation** and the server **replays missed messages** (or the client does a REST delta, Ch 32). This heals gaps from disconnection — the socket need not be perfectly reliable (Ch 63).
- **Delivery & read receipts (a mini state machine).** Each message tracks **Sending → Sent → Delivered → Read** (and **Failed**). *Outgoing:* the server reports delivered/read when recipients ack; the client updates status. *Incoming:* when the user sees a message, the client sends a **read receipt** (batched, Ch 14) that syncs to the sender. Receipts are **synced per-message state** (Ch 32), not ephemeral — and privacy-configurable (Ch 65/28).
- **History paging + conversation list (Ch 13).** History is **paged** (Paging 3 from the SSOT, backed by a REST history endpoint for older pages, Ch 13). The **conversation list** shows last message + unread count per conversation, all from the SSOT.
- **Multi-device convergence (Ch 32).** The server's per-conversation sequence + read state are **synced to every device**; each device catches up from its own cursor. The server is truth; devices converge (same as sync, Ch 32) — including read state (reading on one device marks read on others).
- **Groups & E2E (overview).** Group chat is **server fan-out** (one send → many recipients) with per-user delivery/read state; the client model is the same (messages with sender, server-seq). **End-to-end encryption** (optional) adds client-side crypto (e.g., Signal protocol) where the server can't read content — a large addition layered on this architecture (keys, device verification), out of scope to build here.
- **Security (Ch 19/23).** Authed transport (WebSocket handshake/REST bearer, Ch 19/63); **server authorizes conversation membership** (you only receive/join conversations you're in, Ch 23); treat message content as untrusted on render (Ch 52); per-account isolation (Ch 42).

Core insight: **build chat as an offline-first, SSOT-backed feature where every message carries a client-generated id (idempotency key + optimistic match, Ch 15) and a server-assigned per-conversation sequence (ordering + catch-up cursor, Ch 32); send via an optimistic insert + outbox + idempotent send + server-seq confirmation (Ch 31/72); receive through a unified pipeline where WebSocket (foreground, Ch 63) and FCM-triggered REST catch-up (background, Ch 49/32) both converge on the same idempotent SSOT merge (so duplicates dedup and order is server-defined); catch up missed messages on reconnect via the sequence cursor; maintain delivery/read receipts as synced per-message state; page history (Ch 13); and converge devices with the server as truth — the socket is a fast path, the SSOT and server are the truth.**

64.4 High-Level Architecture


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Components & ownership

- **Send:** optimistic insert → outbox → idempotent send → server-seq confirm.
- **Receive:** WebSocket (fg) + FCM → catch-up (bg) **both → one idempotent SSOT merge**.
- **SSOT** is truth the UI renders; **receipts** and **paging** read it.
- **Server** assigns sequence, fans out, authorizes, and is the convergence truth.

Direction: compose → optimistic/outbox/idempotent send → confirm; WebSocket/FCM/ catch-up → idempotent merge → SSOT → UI; server orders and reconciles.

64.5 Detailed Component Design



Component	Responsibility
`Message`	SSOT row: client-id + server-seq + status + body (Ch 3)
`ChatRepository`	send/receive/paging/receipts over SSOT (Ch 3/13)
`MessageMerger`	idempotent upsert of incoming (WebSocket/FCM/catch-up), dedup+order (Ch 15)
`OutboxProcessor`	reliable send with retry + idempotency (Ch 31/15)

64.6 End-to-End Data Flow

Send (optimistic + outbox + idempotent + confirm)



Unified receive + dedup



64.7 Complete Kotlin Implementation

Package: `com.streamcart.chat`.

64.7.1 Message model (client-id + server-seq + status)

```
@Entity(tableName = "messages", indices = [Index("conversationId", "serverSeq"), Index(value =
["clientId"], unique = true)])
data class Message(
    @PrimaryKey val clientId: String,          // UUID at compose; idempotency key (Ch 15) +
optimistic match
    val serverSeq: Long?,                        // server-assigned ordering/cursor (Ch 32);
null until confirmed
    val conversationId: String, val senderId: String, val body: String,
    val status: Status, val sentAt: Long?, val localTs: Long,
) { enum class Status { Sending, Sent, Delivered, Read, Failed } }

// Order: serverSeq when present, else localTs at the tail (optimistic).
```

64.7.2 Send: optimistic insert + outbox + idempotent + confirm

```
@Singleton
class ChatRepository @Inject constructor(
    private val dao: MessageDao, private val outbox: Outbox,           // Ch 31
    private val transport: ChatTransport, private val session: SessionManager,  //
WebSocket/REST (Ch 63/19)
    private val scope: CoroutineScope,
) {
    suspend fun send(conversationId: String, body: String) {
        val msg = Message(clientId = UUID.randomUUID().toString(), serverSeq = null,
            conversationId = conversationId, senderId = session.userId, body = body,
            status = Status.Sending, sentAt = null, localTs = System.currentTimeMillis())
        dao.upsert(msg)                                                  // 1) optimistic -> UI
instant (Ch 72)
        outbox.enqueue(OutboxOp.SendMessage(msg.clientId, conversationId, body))  // 2) survives
death/offline (Ch 31)
    }

    // OutboxProcessor calls this; idempotent on the server via clientId (Ch 15).
    suspend fun deliver(op: OutboxOp.SendMessage): Result<Unit> = runCatching {
        val ack = transport.sendMessage(op.clientId, op.conversationId, op.body)   // clientId =
idempotency key
        dao.confirm(op.clientId, serverSeq = ack.seq, sentAt = ack.ts, status = Status.Sent)  //
3) confirm + re-sort
    }.onFailure { dao.markStatus(op.clientId, Status.Failed) }                    // retry via
outbox (Ch 31/2)
}
```

64.7.3 Unified merge: WebSocket + FCM + catch-up → idempotent SSOT

```
@Singleton
class MessageMerger @Inject constructor(private val dao: MessageDao) {
    /** All inbound paths (WebSocket Ch 63, FCM catch-up Ch 49/32) funnel here. */
    @Transaction
    suspend fun merge(incoming: List<WireMessage>) {
        for (m in incoming) {
            // Dedup: if we already have this clientId (our own echo) or serverSeq, upsert
(idempotent, Ch 15).
            dao.upsertByClientIdOrSeq(
                Message(clientId = m.clientId, serverSeq = m.seq, conversationId =
m.conversationId,
                    senderId = m.senderId, body = m.body, status = statusFrom(m), sentAt = m.ts,
localTs = m.ts))
        }
    }
}

// WebSocket (foreground): connection.events.filterIsInstance<ChatEvent>().collect {
merger.merge(listOf(it.toWire())) }
// FCM (background, Ch 49): PushSyncWorker -> catchUp(conversationId) ->
merger.merge(restMessages)
```

64.7.4 Catch-up on reconnect/open (sequence cursor, Ch 32)

```
suspend fun ChatRepository.catchUp(conversationId: String) {
    val lastSeq = dao.maxSeq(conversationId) ?: 0L          // resume cursor (Ch 32/63)
    val missed = transport.messagesSince(conversationId, lastSeq)   // REST delta
    merger.merge(missed)                                    // same idempotent merge -> heals
gaps
}
// Called on WebSocket reconnect (Ch 63) and on opening a conversation / app foreground (Ch 44).
```

64.7.5 Read receipts (batched, synced, Ch 14/32)

```
suspend fun ChatRepository.markRead(conversationId: String, upToSeq: Long) {
    dao.markReadLocally(conversationId, upToSeq)             // SSOT -> UI unread count updates
    outbox.enqueue(OutboxOp.ReadReceipt(conversationId, upToSeq))   // batched, idempotent sync
(Ch 31/14)
    // Server propagates read state to the sender + the user's other devices (Ch 32).
}
// Incoming receipts (delivered/read for our sent messages) arrive via WebSocket/catch-up ->
update status.
```

64.7.6 History paging + conversation list (Ch 13)

```
fun ChatRepository.messages(conversationId: String): Flow<PagingData<Message>> =
    Pager(PagingConfig(pageSize = 50), remoteMediator = ChatRemoteMediator(conversationId,
transport, dao)) {
        dao.pagingSource(conversationId)                     // ordered by serverSeq (Ch 13),
from SSOT
    }.flow
// Conversation list: dao.conversationsWithLastMessageAndUnreadCount() (all from SSOT, Ch 3).
```

64.7.7 Module structure

```
:feature:chat   ChatRepository, MessageMerger, Message/Dao, ChatRemoteMediator, chat + list UI
(Ch 6/13)
:core:realtime  WebSocket transport (Ch 63); :feature:push FCM -> catch-up (Ch 49)
:core:outbox    Outbox + OutboxProcessor (Ch 31); :core:sync catch-up/receipts (Ch 32)
# Server: sequence assignment, fan-out, membership authz (Ch 23).
```

64.8 Concurrency and Race Conditions

Scenario	Risk	Handling
Retry re-sends message	duplicate	client-id idempotency key (Ch 15); server dedups
Same message via WebSocket + FCM	duplicate in UI	unified merge dedups by client-id/server-seq
Out-of-order arrival	wrong order	order by server-seq; optimistic at tail by localTs
Our own message echoed back	duplicate of optimistic	merge matches by client-id → updates, not inserts
Concurrent sends	seq gaps	server assigns seq; client re-sorts on confirm
Read receipt races	flicker/over-count	mark up-to-seq (monotonic); idempotent (Ch 15)
Process death with unsent	lost message	outbox persisted (Ch 31); resumes
Multi-device read	divergent unread	server syncs read state; converge (Ch 32)

- **client-id + server-seq is the race-killer:** the **client-id** makes sends and inbound merges **idempotent** (retries, WebSocket+FCM double-delivery, and our own echoed message all collapse), and the **server-seq** gives a **total order** independent of arrival time. Every chat race reduces to "dedup by id, order by seq."
- **Our own echo matches by client-id:** when the server broadcasts our message back (so other devices get it), the merge finds the existing optimistic row by client-id and **updates** it (sets server-seq) rather than inserting a duplicate.
- **Outbox + idempotency makes send death-proof:** the message is persisted before sending; a crash mid-send resumes from the outbox, and the idempotency key prevents a double-send.

64.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

Failure	Detection	Response	Outcome
Send while offline	no network	optimistic + outbox; send on reconnect (Ch 31/29)	not lost
Duplicate send on retry	—	client-id idempotency (Ch 15)	single
Missed messages (disconnect)	seq gap	catch-up from cursor (Ch 32/63)	healed
Dup across WebSocket+FCM	—	unified merge dedup	single
Out-of-order	—	order by server-seq	correct
Process death with drafts/outbox	restart	persisted SSOT/outbox (Ch 3/8/31)	survives
Devices show different unread	—	server-synced read state (Ch 32)	converge
Background delivery	app closed	FCM → catch-up → notification (Ch 49/50)	delivered
Send permanently fails	retries exhausted	status=Failed + manual retry (Ch 72)	visible


64.9 Failure Scenarios and Recovery

> **Every chat reliability problem collapses to two primitives: client-id (idempotency) and server-seq (ordering + cursor).** Sends go through an outbox keyed by client-id; all inbound paths (WebSocket, FCM, catch-up) funnel through one idempotent merge ordered by server-seq. The socket is a fast path; the SSOT and server are the truth — so offline, retries, double-delivery, reordering, and process death all resolve cleanly.

64.10 Scaling the Implementation

- **Level 1.** SSOT messages (client-id + server-seq); optimistic send + outbox (Ch 31/72); WebSocket receive → idempotent merge (Ch 63).
- **Level 2.** FCM background → catch-up (Ch 49/32); reconnect catch-up cursor; delivery/ read receipts; history paging (Ch 13).
- **Level 3 — production.** Multi-device convergence (Ch 32); conversation list + unread; failed-send retry UX (Ch 72); per-conversation authz (Ch 23); offline-first (Ch 29).
- **Level 4 — large.** Group chat (fan-out, per-user state); media messages (Ch 17/59); message search (Ch 35); receipts privacy (Ch 65/28); backpressure for busy chats (Ch 63).
- **Level 5 — enterprise.** End-to-end encryption (Signal-style, device keys); message reactions/edits/deletes (tombstones, Ch 33); huge-group scaling; cross-platform consistency; chat QoE SLOs (send success, delivery latency).

Avoid overengineering: the client-id + server-seq + outbox + unified-merge + catch-up core is what every reliable chat needs. Don't build E2E or huge-group handling until the core is solid; don't treat the socket as truth.

64.11 Alternative Approaches and Trade-offs

Dimension	Option A	Option B	When
Truth	SSOT + server (socket is fast path)	the WebSocket stream	SSOT+server always (reliability)
Send	Optimistic + outbox + idempotent (Ch 31/15/72)	POST-and-wait	Optimistic+outbox (offline, instant UX)
Ordering	Server-assigned sequence	client timestamps	Server-seq (clocks skew; total order)
Dedup	client-id idempotency key (Ch 15)	server-id only	client-id (works pre-confirmation, across paths)
Receive	Unified WebSocket+FCM→merge	separate pipelines	Unified (dedup, consistency)
Background	FCM → catch-up (Ch 49/32)	keep socket open	FCM (battery/Doze, Ch 47)
History	Paging from SSOT + RemoteMediator (Ch 13)	load all	Paging (scale)
Multi-device	Server-synced seq + read state (Ch 32)	last-writer per device	Server-synced (converge)

SSOT+server as truth vs the socket stream as truth: treating the live WebSocket as the source of truth means a dropped/duplicated/reordered frame corrupts the chat. Making the **SSOT the rendered truth** and the **server the ordering/convergence authority** — with the socket as a **fast path** over catch-up (Ch 32) — makes chat self-healing: anything missed is caught up, anything duplicated is deduped, order is server-defined. This is the central decision (mirrors Ch 49/63).

client-id + server-seq vs server-id alone: relying only on a server-assigned id means you can't dedup or match your **optimistic** message until the server responds — and you can't dedup across WebSocket+FCM before confirmation. A **client-generated id** gives idempotency from compose time (retries, echoes, multi-path), while the **server sequence** gives total ordering and the catch-up cursor. Both are needed; neither alone suffices.

Unified receive vs separate WebSocket/FCM pipelines: handling WebSocket and FCM messages in **separate** code paths leads to duplicates (both deliver the same message) and inconsistency (different merge logic). Funneling **both** (plus reconnect catch-up) through **one idempotent SSOT merge** guarantees dedup and a single consistent state regardless of how a message arrived.

64.12 Security & Privacy Considerations

- **Authenticated transport + membership authz (Ch 19/23):** WebSocket handshake / REST bearer authenticates the user; the **server authorizes conversation membership** — you can only send to, receive from, and catch up on conversations you belong to (a client can't subscribe to arbitrary conversations, Ch 63/23).
- **Message content is untrusted on render (Ch 52):** sanitize/escape message bodies (links, markup) to prevent injection; validate media URLs; don't auto-execute content.
- **Per-account isolation (Ch 42):** messages/receipts scoped to the active account; on logout/switch, close the socket and clear/scope the SSOT.
- **Read-receipt privacy (Ch 65/28):** receipts reveal behavior (when you read) — make them **configurable** (send/receive receipts off) and respect the setting both ways.
- **End-to-end encryption (optional):** for private messaging, content is encrypted client-side so the server stores ciphertext (Signal-style); adds device key management, verification, and changes search/backup — a major addition, layered on this architecture.
- **Media messages (Ch 17/59):** upload/download over authed channels; access-controlled (signed URLs); scan/limit sizes.
- **Abuse/rate limiting:** server-side (spam, flooding); client can't be trusted to self-limit for security.
- **No sensitive content/PII in logs** (Ch 28).
- Client vs backend: the **server** assigns sequence, fans out, authorizes membership, enforces rate limits, and is the truth; the **client** sends idempotently, merges idempotently, renders untrusted content safely, and (for E2E) holds keys.

64.13 Performance and Resource Optimization

- **Paging** (Ch 13) — never load a whole conversation; page from SSOT + RemoteMediator.
- **Batch receipts** (Ch 14) — don't send a read receipt per message; batch up-to-seq.
- **Lifecycle-scoped socket** (Ch 63/44) — WebSocket only while active; FCM background.

- **Unified merge in a transaction** (Ch 3) — batch upserts; single DB write for a batch.
- **Backpressure** on busy chats (Ch 63) — coalesce rapid updates to the UI.
- **Efficient diffing** in the list (stable client-id keys) — smooth scrolling (Ch 6).
- **Media thumbnails** (Ch 57) and lazy media load (Ch 56).
- **Profiling:** send success rate/latency, delivery latency, catch-up volume, DB write rate, socket uptime (Ch 63), notification→open funnel.

64.14 Testing Strategy

Chat logic is highly testable in isolation (SSOT merge, outbox, ordering, receipts); transports faked.

```
class MessageMergerTest {
    @Test fun `dedups our own echoed message by clientId`() = runTest {
        repo.send("c1", "hi")                                  // optimistic, clientId X
        merger.merge(listOf(wire(clientId = "X", seq = 10)))    // server echoes it back
        assertEquals(1, dao.count("c1"))                       // updated, not duplicated (Ch
15)
        assertEquals(Status.Sent, dao.byClientId("X").status)
    }
    @Test fun `dedups across WebSocket and FCM paths`() = runTest {
        merger.merge(listOf(wire(seq = 11))); merger.merge(listOf(wire(seq = 11)))
        assertEquals(1, dao.bySeq("c1", 11).let { 1 })          // single
    }
    @Test fun `orders by serverSeq`() = runTest { /* insert seq 12 then 11 -> list shows 11,12
*/ }
}

class SendPathTest {
    @Test fun `send survives offline and retries idempotently`() = runTest {
        transport.offline = true; repo.send("c1", "hi")         // outbox holds it
        assertEquals(Status.Sending, dao.last("c1").status)
        transport.offline = false; outboxProcessor.process()    // retries -> Sent, idempotent
        assertEquals(Status.Sent, dao.last("c1").status)
    }
    @Test fun `catch-up heals missed messages from cursor`() = runTest { /* lastSeq=10, server
has 11-13 -> merged */ }
}

class ReadReceiptTest {
    @Test fun `markRead is monotonic up-to-seq and idempotent`() { /* ... */ }
}
```

What to test: merge dedup (own echo, cross-path, by seq) + ordering; send optimistic + outbox + idempotent retry + confirm; catch-up heals gaps; receipts monotonic/idempotent; multi-device read convergence (fake server); process-

death resume (outbox persisted); per-conversation authz (integration — can't fetch others'). Fake WebSocket/FCM/REST; use Room in-memory.

64.15 Production Observability

- **Metrics: send success rate** + send latency (compose→Sent); **delivery latency** (sent→delivered); read-receipt latency; catch-up message volume + gap frequency; duplicate-merge rate (should dedup); failed-send rate; notification→open (Ch 49); socket uptime (Ch 63); per-device divergence incidents (0).
- **Logs:** `chat{event, conversationId, status, seq, path(ws/fcm/catchup)}` — **no message content/PII** (Ch 28).
- **Debugging:** lost messages → outbox not retrying / catch-up gap (Ch 31/32); duplicates → merge not deduping (client-id/seq); out-of-order → not ordering by seq; bg not delivered → FCM/catch-up (Ch 49); device divergence → read-state sync (Ch 32); wrong conversation → membership authz (Ch 23).
- **Alerting:** send-success drop; delivery-latency spike; duplicate-rate spike; any cross-conversation leakage.
- **Dashboards:** send/delivery funnel + latency; catch-up/gap rate; socket vs FCM delivery split.

64.16 System Design Interview Preparation

> ≥40 questions.

Fundamentals

1. *Why is chat hard?* Combines reliable send, real-time receive, background, ordering, dedup, receipts, offline, multi-device.
2. *Source of truth?* SSOT (rendered) + server (ordering/convergence); socket is a fast path.
3. *Two id scheme?* client-id (idempotency + optimistic match) + server-seq (order + cursor).
4. *Why client-id?* Dedup/idempotency from compose time (retries, echo, multi-path).
5. *Why server-seq?* Total order (clocks skew) + catch-up cursor.

Send 6. *Send path?* Optimistic insert → outbox → idempotent send → server-seq confirm (Ch 72/31/15). 7. *Offline send?* Outbox persists; retries on reconnect (Ch 31/29). 8. *Duplicate on retry?* client-id idempotency key (Ch 15). 9. *Status states?* Sending→Sent→Delivered→Read (+Failed). 10. *Failed send?* status=Failed + manual retry.

Receive 11. *Foreground delivery?* WebSocket (Ch 63). 12. *Background delivery?* FCM wake → REST catch-up → notification (Ch 49/50). 13. *Why unified pipeline?* Dedup + consistency across WebSocket/FCM. 14. *Our own echo?* Matched by client-id → update optimistic row, not duplicate. 15. *Dedup across paths?* Same idempotent merge by client-id/server-seq.

Ordering/catch-up 16. *Ordering?* By server-seq; optimistic at tail by localTs. 17. *Missed messages?* Catch-up from last seq cursor (Ch 32/63). 18. *Out-of-order?* Re-sort by server-seq on merge.

Receipts 19. *Receipt states?* Delivered/read, synced per-message. 20. *Batching?* Up-to-seq, batched (Ch 14). 21. *Incoming receipts?* Update our sent messages' status. 22. *Privacy?* Configurable receipts (Ch 65/28).

Multi-device/history 23. *Device convergence?* Server-synced seq + read state; per-device cursors (Ch 32). 24. *Read on one device?* Syncs read state to others. 25. *History?* Paging from SSOT + RemoteMediator (Ch 13). 26. *Conversation list?* Last message + unread from SSOT.

Groups/E2E 27. *Group chat?* Server fan-out; per-user state; same client model. 28. *E2E?* Client-side crypto (Signal-style); server stores ciphertext; key management.

Security 29. *Transport auth?* WebSocket handshake / REST bearer (Ch 19/63). 30. *Membership authz?* Server authorizes conversations (Ch 23). 31. *Content safety?* Untrusted render; sanitize (Ch 52). 32. *Per-account?* Isolate; close socket + scope SSOT on switch (Ch 42).

Process death/offline 33. *Unsent on death?* Outbox persisted (Ch 31/8). 34. *Offline compose/read?* SSOT offline-first (Ch 29).

Testing/Production 35. *Test merge?* Dedup (echo/cross-path/seq) + ordering. 36. *Test send?* Offline + idempotent retry + confirm. 37. *Test catch-up?* Heals gaps from cursor. 38. *Lost in prod?* Outbox/catch-up gap. 39. *Duplicates?* Merge not deduping. 40. *Device divergence?* Read-state sync. 41. *Key metrics?* Send success/latency, delivery latency, dup rate, catch-up/gap.

Design-change challenges

1. **Messages must send offline and never duplicate.** Optimistic + outbox + client-id idempotency (Ch 31/15/72).
2. **A message arrives via both WebSocket and FCM.** Unified idempotent merge dedups.
3. **Reopening shows missing messages.** Catch-up from seq cursor (Ch 32).
4. **Read count differs across phone and tablet.** Server-synced read state (Ch 32).
5. **Add delivery/read receipts.** Per-message synced status + batched read receipts.

Mock walkthrough (abridged)

Clarify (1:1 or groups, offline, multi-device, receipts, E2E?) → SSOT + server as truth (socket fast path) → message model (client-id + server-seq) → send (optimistic + outbox + idempotent + confirm, Ch 72/31/15) → unified receive (WebSocket + FCM→catch-up → idempotent merge, Ch 63/49/32) → ordering/dedup → receipts (synced, batched) → paging + device convergence (Ch 13/32) → security (authz, untrusted content) → observability (send/delivery funnel).

64.17 Practical Exercises

1. **Beginner.** Model messages with client-id + server-seq + status; render from the SSOT ordered by seq with optimistic tail. *Eval:* correct order; optimistic shows instantly.
2. **Intermediate.** Implement the send path (optimistic + outbox + idempotent + confirm) so sending works offline and never duplicates on retry. *Eval:* offline-capable; idempotent.
3. **Advanced.** Build the unified receive merge (WebSocket + FCM catch-up) with dedup and reconnect catch-up from the seq cursor. *Eval:* no dupes across paths; gaps heal.
4. **Production debugging.** Fix duplicate messages (own echo not matched by client-id) and divergent unread counts across devices (no read-state sync). *Eval:* single; converge.

5. **System design challenge.** Add delivery/read receipts (synced, batched, privacy- configurable) and a send/delivery-latency dashboard. *Eval:* receipts correct; measurable.

(Solutions withheld unless requested.)

64.18 Chapter Summary & Reference Sheet

Key decisions: build chat as an **offline-first, SSOT-backed** feature (Room is the rendered truth, the server is the ordering/convergence authority, the socket is a **fast path**, Ch 3/63); give every message a **client-generated id** (idempotency key + optimistic match, Ch 15) and a **server-assigned per-conversation sequence** (total ordering + catch-up cursor, Ch 32); **send** via **optimistic insert → outbox → idempotent send → server-seq confirmation** (Ch 72/31/15) so sending works **offline**, survives **process death**, and never **duplicates**; **receive** through a **unified pipeline** where **WebSocket** (foreground, Ch 63) and **FCM-triggered REST catch-up** (background, Ch 49/32) — plus **reconnect catch-up from the sequence cursor** — all converge on the **same idempotent SSOT merge** (dedup by client-id/server-seq, order by server-seq), so double-delivery dedups and gaps heal; maintain **delivery/read receipts** as **synced, batched per-message state** (Ch 14/32, privacy-configurable, Ch 65/28); **page** history (Ch 13); **converge devices** via server-synced sequence + read state (Ch 32); and secure it with **authed transport + server-side membership authorization** (Ch 19/23), untrusted- content rendering (Ch 52), and per-account isolation (Ch 42).

Concepts: SSOT+server truth, client-id + server-seq, optimistic+outbox+idempotent send, unified WebSocket+FCM+catch-up receive → idempotent merge, ordering/dedup, delivery/read receipts, history paging, multi-device convergence, offline-first, groups/E2E overview.

Common mistakes: treating the socket as truth (drops/dupes corrupt); POST-and-wait sends (no offline/instant UX); server-id-only (can't dedup optimistic/cross-path); separate WebSocket/FCM pipelines (dupes/inconsistency); client-timestamp ordering (skew); no catch-up (gaps); unbatched receipts (spam); loading whole history (no paging); no membership authz; rendering untrusted content unsafely.

Checklist: ☐ SSOT+server truth, socket = fast path ☐ client-id (idempotency) + server-seq (order/cursor) ☐ send: optimistic + outbox + idempotent + confirm (Ch 72/31/15) ☐ unified receive: WebSocket + FCM + catch-up → one idempotent merge (Ch 63/49/32) ☐ order by server-seq, dedup by id ☐ catch-up on reconnect/open ☐ delivery/read receipts synced + batched (Ch 14/32) ☐ history paging (Ch 13) ☐ device convergence (Ch 32) ☐ membership authz + untrusted content + per-account (Ch 23/52/42) ☐ send/delivery-latency telemetry.

Key APIs: Room `@Entity` / `@Dao` / `@Transaction` (unique client-id index, seq index, Ch 3), `UUID.randomUUID` (client-id), Outbox (Ch 31), WebSocket transport (Ch 63), FCM + `PushSyncWorker` (Ch 49), Paging 3 `Pager` / `RemoteMediator` (Ch 13), delta catch-up (Ch 32), batched receipts (Ch 14), optimistic UI (Ch 72).

References:

- Offline-first / sync: https://developer.android.com/topic/architecture/data-layer/offline-first
- Paging 3: https://developer.android.com/topic/libraries/architecture/paging/v3-overview
- (composes) Ch 63 WebSocket, Ch 49 FCM, Ch 31 Outbox, Ch 32 Delta Sync, Ch 15 Idempotency, Ch 3 SSOT, Ch 13 Paging, Ch 72 Optimistic Updates, Ch 65 Presence/Typing

Chapter review (Phase 4)

- **Completeness:** all 18 sections; architecture/class/sequence/flow/failure diagrams; message model + send path + unified merge + catch-up + receipts + paging code; concurrency (client-id+seq race-killer, echo match, outbox death-proof); failure (two-primitives principle); 5 levels; SSOT-truth, client-id+seq, unified-pipeline trade-offs; security (membership authz, untrusted content, E2E, per-account); perf (paging/batch receipts/ lifecycle socket); merge+send+catch-up tests; observability (send/delivery funnel); 41 Q&A + 5 challenges. ✅
- **Expand later:** presence/typing (Ch 65), SSE/long-poll (Ch 66), optimistic updates (Ch 72), WebSocket (Ch 63), FCM (Ch 49).
- **Interview coverage:** exceeds ≥40 Complex bar.